

The Next Decade

What to Watch?

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No this isn't an entertainment story telling you what Netflix shows to watch... it's about the headlines we expect from science and technology over the next decade... the developments that will make us sit up and take notice.

Our cutting Edge section is perfect for this cover story of the Next Decade, because that is the exact brief of the section – identify technologies that are cutting edge right now, which will be mainstream, or be common in under a decade... Think of it as a teaser for what's to come in upcoming issues. Make sure to write in to us and tell us which ones you'd like us to cover more in-depth, and we will do exactly that.

A.I.

Again, like you would have done when you read my column, you're probably going "No sh*t Sherlock!" right about now. The problem is that machine learning is being used for everything. And we mean: Every. Effing. Thing.

If you're in school looking for a sure-shot career that will bring in the big bucks for the next few decades, getting into AI is a no-brainer. We expect both startups and established companies to use AI capabilities in very interesting and new ways, and bring it into domains that aren't as obvious as most.

For example, you'd never expect AI to take over wildlife conservation, and yet it is. It's not even "cutting edge" because sites like Wildbook.org have existed for at least three years now. It's helping wildlife researchers use

photographs taken by professionals, tourists, dashcams, anything, to use location data and image recognition to keep a tab of which animal is where. It's like Facebook's facial recognition, but for everything from African wildlife to dolphins and whales. While it's very hard for us to tell a couple of zebras apart, AI can do so effortlessly.

It's also being used in areas that will yield phenomenal changes in the next 10 years – medicine, warfare (cyber or otherwise), data mining, predictions (stock or betting, etc), driving... just everywhere!

HIV cured!

The last remaining deadly STD will no longer be a threat to lives. A team led by the famous Dr. Gupta from AIIMS held a press conference yesterday to announce that a cure for HIV had been successfully tested on a sample of over 700 humans and had achieved a 98.8 percent cure rate. Funded by the Indian government, the cure will be made available for free to all countries in order to eradicate HIV once and for all. Dr Gupta is already set to start trialing an HIV-vaccine next month, and his latest success comes just 6 years after he found a cure for the Herpes Simplex virus in 2022.

SPACE EXPLORATION

As we try and explore further and further away from our little blue marble, we run into light speed communication delay problems. This is why autonomous robots are the future of almost all space exploration. With companies like SpaceX helping to make launches cheaper, and scientists at ISRO outdoing even Elon Musk when it comes to space launches on a budget, we think the next decade will involve far more countries than have been traditionally involved in space exploration thus far.

When it comes to rockets, and other launch technologies, it's people like Musk who will lead the charge, and as expertise rises, costs will fall even further. Low earth orbit is poised to become what air travel was in the early days of flying – at first something only the rich could partake in, to eventually becoming basically public transport in the sky. Of course in a mere decade we won't achieve that, but we do hope to see the wealthy being shot out into zero G orbits in under 10 years.

Soon after you read this, we expect China to launch it's Chang'e 4 mission which will attempt to land a rover on the far side of the moon. No one has ever even attempted this, and it's considered to be technically far more difficult than even the Apollo missions, which all landed near the equator on the near side of the moon (the side that faces earth).

Why do they want to do this? Because the payoff is huge for scientific exploration of the cosmos. For one